FAQs: We've Asked Ourselves the Same Questions

"Why do we need religious diplomacy when we already have so many interfaith dialogue organizations—and isn't diplomacy a political term than has nothing to do with religion?"

Interfaith dialogue and religious diplomacy represent different approaches to improving chances for peace where challenging conflicts are influenced in part by religious differences. Interfaith dialogue aims to find common ground on which to build consensus, and it attracts those already committed to conversation and compromise to end conflict. However, adversaries in deep religious and ideological conflicts often are not interested in compromise, and do not see the benefit of interfaith dialogue. The term diplomacy denotes the work of mutual persuasion for change not just mutual understanding of perspectives. Adversaries or rivals can see benefits from religious diplomacy that might convert their critics' attitudes, beliefs and actions without expecting a compromise of convictions. In recent years researchers have found that interfaith dialogue does not lead to trusting, peaceful outcomes among adamant rivals or adversaries. Studies by the Wolff Institute, as well as scholars working in the behavioral sciences, demonstrate the need for alternative approaches for improving conflicts influenced by religion. Religious diplomacy shows promise in this effort to engage parties that most need to meet if any change in attitude is to occur. FRD supports scientific research for more understanding of the challenges and more effective approaches to trust and peace building.

"Does this mean you are opposed to interfaith dialogue?"

Not at all! Interfaith dialogue does build understanding of common values that can lead to collaboration between religious communities. Many humanitarian aid projects with billions of donated dollars and hours are accomplished through joint efforts of different religious traditions. Interfaith cooperation can have strong positive impact on economic and political matters when moral alignment of religious citizens is achievable. However, interfaith dialogue is not the best approach in bringing people resistant to conversations to the table to build enough trust to tackle intractable conflicts. Religious diplomacy aims at reaching such individuals and groups to build trust and goodwill by facing their unresolvable differences and continually seeking the whole truth together.

"Is it really possible to bring people to the table and build trust when they hold onto their irreconcilable differences and find criticism threatening?"

It can be a challenge, but it is possible. For over 20 years FRD has brought people together to have conversations and build trust despite irreconcilable differences, including Orthodox Israeli Jews and Egyptian Sunnis, Iranian Shi'ites and American Christians, liberal Buddhists and conservative Christians, Satanist atheists and Evangelicals, and more. FRD has found that people who disagree about fundamental beliefs and value priorities can desire to engage in order 1) to

learn how to persuade the other to change their negative attitudes or positions, or 2) to convert the other's religious convictions. In either case there is pressure to change something by means of respectful persuasion since the status quo is not working. They are willing to experiment with respectful engagement instead of suppressing their rival's voice or engaging violently. In short, changing attitudes about the trustworthiness of an adversary or rival is enough to improve the world a lot without resolving ever-ongoing conflicts over ultimate reality. To build trust, however, conflicts must be faced not evaded. Peaceful tension is thus the goal.

"Why do you focus on deep differences? Shouldn't we focus on our commonalities?

Although interfaith organizations and political unifiers focus on commonalities (while recognizing differences) they tend to believe that "what unites us is more important that what divides us." Sometimes that is so, but many times our unique differences are most important. In social life we focus on the *uniqueness* of each person more than the fact we are all homo sapiens. We must face the truth that we compare and evaluate differences—including our divergent belief systems that exhibit irreconcilable, momentous differences. As Stephen Prothero argued in his book *God is Not* One, when we ignore this in an effort to achieve peace, we offend rather than soothe. Prothero says "pretend pluralism'—celebrating diversity as long as differences don't really matter—leads to resentment and antagonism, not respect and peace. FRD builds trust by acknowledging strong differences that matter head-on in sincere Heart & Mind Conversations--not shallow learning, nor heated debate. What we aim to have in common is *mutual respect and trust* between honest critics, opponents and rivals even when they contest the most important matters in life.

"Why do you use the term 'religious rivals'? It sounds so negative."

The term "rivalry" has troubling connotations, but this doesn't always have to be the case. Rivals for power go to war against each other, but there is also a beneficial creative rivalry that is not contentious. It yields exertion for excellence in most forms of competition, in business, arts, and sports. The reality is that rivalry is unavoidable in social life. But we can choose to envy and hate our rivals (and ourselves for not being *them*), or we can choose to admire and even love our rivals for the good they do. Buddhists call this *mudita,* the happiness we experience in the good or success of another. On this theme, the Qur'an (Sura 5:48) says Allah might have made all cultures and religions the same, but in order to create a rivalry in righteousness Allah made the world diverse. Righteous rivals might try to out-love each other. That's a win/win contest! However, in the realm of religion when salvation is on the line for many, the contest over rival true ways is more serious than material competitions. Seriously, in a world of diverse rival persuasions, we are all converts, "giving our lives" to the way we follow. FRD embraces inevitable religious rivalries and works to build trust and good will between advocates of different persuasions.

"You work at building good will but then refer to 'trustworthy rivalry,' 'cooperative contestation,' and 'peaceful co-resistance.' Aren't these terms contradictory to good will?"

This question is related to the terminology in relation to "religious rivalry." To be clear, FRD does not advocate conflict resolution *per se*, where the goal is to end the problem with consensus or compromise. When individuals and groups fundamentally disagree over deep beliefs and values, often the way toward peaceful relations is through continual, respectful contestation. In American history Roger Williams (in the 1640's) and James Madison (in the 1780's) promoted a lively experiment for social order via vigorous persuasion contests between diverse religious or political rivals. The very foundations of truth were continually subjects for contestation in dynamic America. It's still an experiment. However, FRD has discovered that prior to a disagreement, good will must be presumed for trust to take root and thrive among rival contestants. In American and anywhere else, this attitude allows the tension of conflict to be digestible, as rivals come to see themselves in each other—only desiring to convert heart and minds by honest persuasion without threat of legal or physical violence. This can sustain enough mutual trust for participants to desire to live in peaceful co-resistance while engaging in cooperative contestation over the common good—even collaborating in full agreement from time to time!

"Why do you employ John and Julie Gottman's research regarding successful long-term marriages to support your methods for facing unresolvable religious disagreements?"

John and Julie Gottman studied long-term successful marriages and discovered that about sixty-six percent of the conflicts in those marriages were never resolved. This challenged the common notion that unresolved disagreements made couples too incompatible to live together peacefully. Gottman observed that essential marital trust was enhanced when couples realized their loyalty and good will was strong enough to overtly include their differences. In short, they could be "whole people" that respected each other while re-engaging their unresolved disagreements as needed from time to time—even when it was a matter of significant value priorities. This finding seemed to provide a model experiment for our interconnected world of diverse peoples that are inevitably involved in mass arranged marriage on earth. Gottman provokes us to question the idea that healthy social-political relations require a stable consensus or compatibility in fundamental beliefs and values. We surmised that if the general expectation of a diverse society with contested values could be to live among trustworthy people that agreed to periodic rituals of mutual persuasion, peacefulness would become normal because it included healthy digestion (not avoidance) of the tension of unresolvable conflicts. In our view, Rene Girard's social order theory of violent explosive scapegoating through human sacrifice, would be replaced by a theory of cathartic expression of unabsorbed resistance and collaborative embrace. Rather than killing someone to evade internal conflict, we engage the conflict boldly, finding enough trust and love to sustain it.

"Don't religious conversations end in dogmatic stubbornness and anger over unresolvable truth claims? Shouldn't we just focus on material issues open to negotiated compromise?"

Convictions about the big questions of life's purpose and how it is to be lived—no matter how contested they might be—deeply influence our most important *practical* decisions. We gain our beliefs and values from authorities we trust. Practical decisions open to compromise are based on values that undergird and guide us along with high stakes life-ordering decisions about love and marriage, work and war, education, tax policy, social justice issues, and many more matters. Most of the time unresolvable disagreements over beliefs and values derive from the question of the trustworthiness of authorities we encounter. All truth claims could be continually contested—not out of stubbornness but with sincere inquiry. We naturally decided to trust without verification to avoid the exhausting inefficiency of perpetual skepticism. So, humans decide authorities they will trust, and with self-awareness confess to *how* and *why* they came to adopt important beliefs and values—the comprehensive ones that order everything else—the ones they don't desire to negotiate or compromise. Indeed, sharing how we came to our convictions and value priorities is the best way to get to the heart of all the *practical* things that matter to us.

"Who should engage in effect religious diplomacy? Is it not a specialty for religious leaders?"

When the goal is broad influence, and the power of social media is available, religious diplomacy can be effective for both top-down and bottom-up influencers. To build trust within and between communities, ordinary insiders need to engage outsiders—and dissident insiders with the initial presumption of mutual good faith. Of course, influential leaders can model respectful, even vulnerable heart and mind conversations for their devout communities, but religious institutions and leaders are waning in social influence in many places. Many folks today don't care to observe authorities debate rival truth claims about anything that confuse the hearers. Instead, many people are seeking authentic interpersonal conversations between people that are not dogmatic about religious and ideological differences. The grassroots engagement has exploded online where the thoughts of less informed friends become authoritative "influencers." While the influence of religious leaders is still powerful, a worldwide decentralization of information is quickly spreading. To be broadly helpful, religious diplomacy should become a common practice between rival religious cultural influencers, both institutional and grass roots, giving voice to both general and ad hoc authorities. Through many perspectives truth can be approximated.

How is FRD funded, and what perspectives are brought to your work in religious diplomacy?

FRD is an independent NGO funded by individuals or groups that promote free and open persuasion of all by all—subject to laws that try to balance freedom and harmful behavior. We are not solely funded by any particular religious group, nor do we operate from within a single religious or philosophical tradition. Our President, Executive Director, Senior Fellows, and obviously Chapter Directors, come from a variety of religious traditions and acknowledge that their perspectives and biases influence all they think and do. While advocating their deepest

convictions, they pledge to account for their biases and openly try to learn and be influenced by others' perspectives. Generally, FRD's mission aims to build trust and good will between people with radically different religious or ideological views and value priorities—presuming peaceful tension within and between individuals, groups and societies is the optimum way for humans to live—so far.

"Is religious diplomacy just a cover for proselytization?"

Attempting to persuade others to change is indeed off-limits in traditional interfaith dialogue. In fact, some involved in interfaith work consider it unethical. FRD strongly disagrees with this attitude in the trust and peace-building community. In terms of social psychology, it is unrealistic. We usually directly or indirectly desire to persuade others that our views are right enough, or the best among various options. Many today hold the view that no perspective on truth is better than another, but of course, want to persuade others that! We are all daily persuaders. Persuasion is not just for business marketing; it is fundamental in terms of expressing our desires and preferences, and where the stakes are higher, persuasion is vital to our interpersonal, social, and political well-being. Importantly, ethical concerns over social power differences should be honestly considered whenever *mutual* persuasion is the goal—as with religious diplomacy. But since inequality of social power is *always* a factor, it must not keep us from communicating. Religious diplomacy has an agenda broader than mutual persuasion to change—mutual learning and even collaboration are also lively prospects in Heart & Mind Conversations. Nevertheless, converting hearts to care and trust is always a present motive. The aim of mutual conversion of attitudes is thus an overt—never hidden motive crucial to trust-building. In case anyone is concerned about the ethics of FRD's approach, the foundation has published its pledge and call for others to engage in persuasion that optimizes the goal of long-term trust and mutual benefit. Here is FRD's declaration of *Commitment to Ethical Persuasion*.